

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 201

By McNally

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Margaret Jewel "Margie" Ison of Knoxville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Knoxville broadcast legend Margaret Jewel "Margie" Ison; and

WHEREAS, for more than three decades, thousands of East Tennesseans welcomed Margie Ison into their homes, most notably as the longtime meteorologist with WBIR in Knoxville; more than simply a trusted source of weather information, she became a treasured presence who felt like a friend to so many; and

WHEREAS, born in Brotherton on July 7, 1940, Mrs. Ison was the daughter of Reverend Samuel Ernest "S.E." Wood and Daisy Jewel Jernigan Wood and attended Central Cookeville High School, where she was voted by her peers as "Most Talented" and produced her own radio show with WHUB in Cookeville; and

WHEREAS, it was also during high school that she met the love of her life, Jim Ison, while singing with the high school orchestra at a church event; the two were married in Ringgold, Georgia, on December 28, 1957; and

WHEREAS, Margie Ison's television career began in Chattanooga in the 1960s, when she sang on the *Roy Morris Variety Show* on WRCB and worked as the entertainment support during a special program celebrating Chattanooga's 150th anniversary; and

WHEREAS, she came on board at Knoxville's WBIR-TV Channel 10 in 1969 as a "weather girl," having no previous experience or credentials as a meteorologist at the time; a popular addition to the newscast, she blazed a trail as the station's first weather forecaster and would inspire many others to take up the mantle after her; and

WHEREAS, after her initial stint with WBIR, she left to work at WATE-TV Channel 6 from 1971 to 1979, during which time she reported the weather at 6:00 p.m. and 11:00 p.m. and hosted a daily talk show; she returned to WBIR in 1979, bringing thousands of viewers with her, which pushed WBIR to the top of local broadcast ratings; and

WHEREAS, during her tenure as a Knoxville meteorologist, her infectious personality cemented her as a local legend, with many parroting her catchphrase, "Margie said it would," a nod to the trust she had earned among her viewers who knew they could count on her forecasts; and

WHEREAS, Margie Ison's distinguished tenure also included entertainment reporting with "Margie on Location" segments that covered music and art from the local Knoxville area, throughout the East Tennessee region, and beyond, including Dollywood, the Grand Ole Opry, Opryland, the CMA Awards, Fan Fair, and the annual Cowboy Gold International Bluegrass Music Festival in Kumamoto, Japan, in 1990; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Ison created the Area Weather Spotter Network, which is still in effect today, and utilized the Ham Radio Operators and the National Weather Service to gather accurate weather information and forecasts; and

WHEREAS, although she retired from WBIR in 1995, she filled in temporarily as a guest weather personality on WATE from 1996 to 2001; she was also in the Knoxville and East Tennessee area as a keynote speaker and as vocal entertainment for various organizations; and

WHEREAS, devoted to serving her community, Mrs. Ison served on the Board of Directors for Goodwill Industries of Knoxville for more than twenty years and also served on the advisory board of the Caswell Boys and Girls Club and the Interfaith Health Clinic board, and she participated in fundraising telethons for the East Tennessee Children's Hospital March of Dimes, the Jerry Lewis M & A telethon, and PBS Channel 2 telethon; and

WHEREAS, she received the Sertoma Service to Mankind School Bell Award for her work with special education students, was honored for her work with Goodwill Industries Annual Vintage fashion show and the Teen Board of Knoxville, and received the Southern Diva Award from the Senior Citizens Home Assistant Services Organization; and

WHEREAS, a woman of abiding faith, Margie Ison attended Church Street United Methodist Church and was a member of the Parables class; and

WHEREAS, she was also deeply devoted to her family, and she always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Ison is survived by her daughters, Debbie (Jeff) Williams and Jill (David) McMillan; grandchildren, Alex Stidham, Josh (Kalie) Stidham, Brigitte (Caleb) Stair, and Brittany (Taylor) Benziger; great-grandchildren, Eli Stidham, Ezra Stidham, Jude Stidham, Eliana Bond, Josiah Bond, Michaela Bond, Isaiah Bond, Judy Benziger, and Gene Benziger; brother, Dr. Albert Wood; special godson, Larry (Lori) Cannon and family; Brent Cannon and Alexa Kaye (Derek) Lusby, Ellie Britt, and Rowen Lusby; and several nieces and nephews; and

WHEREAS, in addition to her parents, she was preceded in death by her beloved husband of sixty-five years, James Ira "Jim" Ison, and her siblings, Judy Wood and Samuel E. Wood; and

WHEREAS, Margie Ison often relied on her deep connection with viewers, sometimes even visiting them in their homes; seeing her warmth and her grace, people could not help but be drawn to her kind, caring, and nurturing spirit; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Margaret Jewel "Margie"

Ison, reflecting fondly upon her impeccable character and her stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mrs. Ison.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.